

# 10 Classic Games

## Pitfall — Atari 2600

You're Pitfall Harry, the world famous jungle explorer and fortune hunter extraordinaire. *Pitfall* started the sidescrolling version of adventure gameplay that was used in many 2D games. (1982)

## Pac-Man — Atari

One of the most famous games from the Atari generation, it's *Pac-Man*'s story of survival in a maze, amidst ghosts, dots and power pills. (1983)

## Yie Ar Kung Fu — Spectrum

The first fighting game. Fighting games owe it to this one for inspiring a successful genre on the console. (1985)

## Contra — NES

What would the NES be without

*Contra*? You play as the Rambo-esque character shooting bizarre enemies, collect weapons with platform elements such as jumping puzzles, moving platforms, and of course, the mandatory end-level boss. (1986)

## Super Mario — NES

*Mario* (and Luigi) run and jump through eight different worlds, eating mushrooms in a contrived adventure to save the Princess. With secret levels, power ups, and warp zones, *Mario* was one of the most fun games ever. (1986)

## F-19 Stealth Fighter — PC

This was Microprose's *Doom* of flight simulators. *F-19* found the perfect balance between complexity and fun, attracting both purists and newbies. (1988)

## Prince of Persia — PC

Rescue your beloved princess from the evil clutches of Grand Vizier Jaffar. You travel through dungeons and the castle to find her within an hour, swordfighting along the way. (1989)

## Atari 2000 Robotron — Atari

Move and fire in eight directions to repel the swarm of robots attempting to destroy you and save your human family in the process. (1983)

## Dune 2 — PC

*Dune 2* is the grand daddy of all RTS (Real-time Strategy) games on the PC. Based on the *Dune 2* novels by Frank Herbert, it's one of the most action-packed and addictive games of all time. (1992)

*Online*, *Everquest* and *Asheron's Call* are some of the most popular names in the business. *Everquest* boasts of over 300,000 players.

## Speed demons

As newer games demanded more realistic 3D environments, the drain on computing resources made it difficult for game programmers to devote resources to the gameplay itself. Even with monumental advances in computing power as offered by processors, game development was slowed by the inability of computers to keep up with the demands of 3D graphics. To address this demand, 3DFX released its

new Voodoo Graphics chipset in late 1996. 3DFX revolutionised the industry by outclassing available Pentium processors and other dedicated 3D products in 3D performance. Its proprietary Glide API was successful during a short period between 1997-98. It wasn't until Microsoft developed a 3D command language called Direct3D that the 3DFX/Glide domination began to crack. nVidia was one of the first companies to jump on the Direct3D bandwagon, and its GeForce range of cards rule the roost today.

As desktop computing power has exploded, so have the graphics capabilities of the PC. During the unveiling of the

GeForce 3, Steve Jobs talked about the time when they had to pre-render *Toy Story* on a Cray Supercomputer. It took them 1,000 hours to get 1,000 frames of decent animation. Now with the GeForce3, they can render the same scene at 60 frames per second.

The early games were addictive fun—fun in its most basic form. Today we have games with genres and subgenres, each with its own culture and clique that is being defined and refined all the time. The graphics and the sound will keep advancing to a point where it's as good as the real thing. But graphics maketh not a game. If you take away all the fancy graphics, sound, story, character development, puzzles and dialogue, then every game out there is just

*Pong*. All said and done, a death-match is similar to **Pac-Man** in 3D, and RPG games are just imaginative storytelling. ■

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## Ethical Warez

Video Game Emulators are programs that allow you to run video games on your PC. Emulators are legal as long as they don't contain copyrighted material. ROMs on the other hand are a different ball game. In the case of discontinued systems, classic gaming enthusiasts release the ROM images since the company is not making any money out of it, anyway. In a situation where buying the game is out of the question, it seems ethical to 'warez' these games. Classic gamers refer to such files as abandonware. But not all ROM images are copyrighted. Some companies release their

games to the public domain or for not-for-profit distribution. An example of this is ROMs for the Vectrex. These are perfectly legal, so long as they're not distributed for profit. Another interesting development is the concept of New Classics, a term used to describe new games written for old systems. People are still writing games for the ColecoVision, the Atari 2600, Gameboy and other systems. Programmers write the game and release it as a ROM image. They don't need to make a cartridge, since emulators can run their game. It's all for fun, and nobody is complaining.

